



PATH 19

Automation setups

A named setup that still runs a week later. Not "I'll automate your company."

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Who this is for

You can connect a model to email, a sheet, or a form without setting their building on fire. You have built at least one of these for yourself.

Time to first

7–21 days

Tools

First sale

One paid setup that still runs a week later without you in the Slack.

Cash window

\$400–\$2,500 named setups

Leave this alone

Make, Zapier, n8n, or native Claude/ChatGPT connectors. A form they already use. A runbook page. Open-ended retainers with no named job. God-mode logins. Sending without a human check on day one.

What this actually is

You sell a named machine. Lead form to draft reply. Weekly report to Slack. Invoice reminder that waits for a human. The name is the product. "I'll automate your company" is how you vanish into their operations and never send a second invoice.

A setup is done when it still runs a week later without you in the Slack. You hand off a one-page runbook. You support it for 14 days. Then it is theirs, or they buy a new named package.

The work is not "adding AI." The work is design, least privilege, tests with fake data, an off switch a tired owner can find, and a week of drafts that did not embarrass them. If you cannot write the before and after on one line, you do not have an offer. You have a hobby with logins.

What this is not

It is not an operations overhaul. It is not a retainer that says "automations as needed." It is not sitting in their inbox as a junior assistant. It is not rebuilding their website so leads "capture properly" unless they paid for that as a different job.

It is not a Zap you click together on a sales call and walk away from. A \$20/month tool with no owner is cheaper than you and worse. You are selling the named job, the tests, and two weeks of you on the hook.

It is not sending mail, posting, or charging without a human check on day one. Native buttons without a runbook are how a junior sends a wrong quote at 6am.

Why this works now

Forms, inboxes, and sheets already sit in every small shop. Models made a decent first draft cheap. What those shops do not have is a pipe that drafts in their voice, waits for a tap, and can be paused on a Thursday without calling a developer. That pipe is the setup.

Owners are tired of tools they turned on and then feared. They have been burned by a message that went out wrong, or by a workspace nobody owns. Trust is the actual product. The first time an automated message goes to the wrong person, they will not remember your cleverness. They will remember that you had no off switch.

You do not need an agency site. You need one machine you can demo on your own accounts, a price, and two people with messy inboxes.

Three anti-patterns

The first anti-pattern is god-mode. You take admin access "to do it right" and become the person who resets 2FA. Least privilege is slower on Tuesday and cheaper for the rest of the year.

The second is automating a process that has never been done manually. If they have never replied to a lead by hand, you are not automating a job. You are debugging a fantasy. Make them do it twice on paper, or pick a different machine.

The third is the unnamed retainer. "I'll hop in the workspace." That sentence has no done. Fourteen days of break-fix on a named flow has a done. "Automations as needed" is a salary they forget to pay.

The deal you keep

You keep one named flow, scoped to named tools, in writing. You keep a human check on anything that sends, posts, or charges until they ask in writing to remove it. You keep a one-page runbook with the off switch in the first paragraph. You keep a 14-day support window, then you leave extra access. You keep the right to quote a second machine as a second job. That deal is the business.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you can connect a model to email, a sheet, or a form without setting their building on fire. You have built at least one of these for yourself. You can draw the flow on one page. You know what least privilege means, even if you learned it the embarrassing way.

You will write a runbook. People who hate documentation should pick a different path. The runbook is not extra. It is half the product. A machine nobody can pause is a liability with your name on it.

This fits you if

You already use Make, Zapier, n8n, or a native Claude or ChatGPT connector for a real job, not a tutorial.

You can explain an off switch in two sentences.

You will test with fake data you own, never with their real customers.

You can sit through a twenty-minute walkthrough without turning it into a webinar.

You have two people who have complained, in your hearing, about a form that dumps into a void.

Skip this path if

Skip it if you want an open-ended retainer with no named job. Skip it if you have never tested with fake data. Skip it if you need god-mode logins to feel useful. Skip it if the process has never been done manually.

Skip it if you need cash this week. A brief or a productized service is faster. This path takes 7–21 days to a first paid setup because access, testing, and the runbook are the work. A demo on your laptop is not a first sale. The first sale is a machine that still ran on day 8.

Skip it if you will not write a one-page runbook. If documentation feels beneath you, you will ship a clever branch you cannot explain, and you will get an 11pm text in week three.

The honest middle

If you have a Make scenario for your own leads that has run for a month, that is the product. Record eight minutes of it. Price it. Offer it to two people. You are not waiting to become an "AI ops" firm. You are waiting to name the machine and put a deposit on it.

If you have only built tutorial zaps, build one on your own form this week. Fake names. Approval on. Runbook. Then sell that shape. Do not learn a new tool on their dime.

Skills and time

You need evenings for the demo and the one-pager, then a build week that can absorb access delays. The build itself is often two or three focused sessions. The calendar time is longer because they are slow with logins. Plan for that. Support days are break-fix, not a second job, but you must be reachable for 14 days.

You need to talk about permissions without flinching. "I need the form, the one inbox or label, and the one sheet. Not your Google admin." If that sentence feels rude, this path will train you into god-mode.

Two-minute self-test

Answer these out loud. If two are blank, skip this path this month.

Name one machine in one line, with a before and after.

Name the off switch in two sentences.

Name the tool you can demo this week on your own accounts.

Name two people with a messy inbox or a form that dumps into a void.

Say what you will not access, even if they offer the admin password.

If all five have answers, record the demo today. If the off switch is fuzzy, you have nothing to sell yet.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this before you open Make: "Named setup: [trigger] to [result] with your approval. Tools: [named]. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$[price]."

Kai's sentence is the default: "Named setup: form to draft reply with your approval. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750." Yours can swap the machine. Keep the shape. If it needs a paragraph, split it into two products and sell one.

Five sentences you can copy

Named setup: Tally or Typeform to Gmail draft with your approval. Make plus Claude. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750.

Named setup: weekly sheet of closed jobs to a Slack post every Monday 8am. Zapier plus their existing sheet. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750.

Named setup: unpaid invoice in Stripe or their sheet to a draft reminder in Gmail, never sent until they tap. \$750.

Named setup: new Google review to a draft reply in a Doc, with approval before anything posts. \$750.

Named setup: job application form to a row in a sheet plus a Slack ping, no auto-reject, human next. \$1,200 if the sheet is already a mess.

Write yours with a trigger they already have. Do not write "AI operations for growing teams." That is not a machine.

What they get

One named flow, scoped to named tools, in writing.

A one-page diagram before you build.

Tests with fake data you own.

Human approval on anything that sends, posts, or charges, until they ask in writing to remove it.

A one-page runbook: how to pause, how to know it broke, who to ping during the 14 days.

A twenty-minute walkthrough where they pause it once with you watching.

Fourteen days of break-fix after handoff. Then a new package if they want more.

What they do not get

Rewiring their whole company. Unlimited extra zaps. Sitting in their inbox as a junior assistant. Keeping their passwords in your password manager forever. Sending without approval on day one. A new CRM as a prerequisite. A second language, a second brand, or a Slack fork "while we are in there." If they want a second machine, it is a second quote.

They also do not get you on call after day 14 unless they buy a check-in. Watching it is how you become unpaid ops.

Packaging

One named machine. Price on a one-pager. 50 percent to start, 50 percent on handoff. Tools named. What is out named. Support end date named.

Do not sell a \$99 special that cannot pay for the runbook. Do not quote one price for "all the zaps they might want." Do not throw in a website rebuild. If they need a form that does not exist, you may stand up a Tally form as part of the \$750 if you write it in the scope. That is still one machine, not a digital transformation.

What done looks like

Done is a setup that still runs on day 8 without you poking it. The client can pause it without calling you. The runbook is in a folder they own. Your access is the least they needed, and you have a calendar reminder to remove yourself after the support window if they do not need you.

Done is not "the zap turned green on my laptop." A demo on your accounts is a sales asset. The first sale is their machine, in their tools, still drafting a week later.

The fairness test

You do not log in "just to check." They send you a screenshot or a sample output from the week. If it failed silently, the runbook failed. You fix that inside the 14 days as support, then you write the failure into the runbook so it does not stay tribal knowledge.

Fairness also means they can pause it. If they cannot find the toggle without you, you are not done, even if the drafts look pretty. Fairness means the diagram matches what you built. A clever branch you did not draw is a gift they did not ask for and a bug you will own at 11pm.

Technical done

Diagram, runbook, and tool logins they control.

Off switch labeled in the first paragraph of the runbook, with a screenshot.

Fake-data tests saved.

Human approval on send, post, or charge.

They paused it once in front of you.

Support end date in writing. Not "I'm around."

Remaining invoice sent at handoff.

Day 8: they confirm it ran. Day 14: extra access removed.

Not done yet

You are still in their Google admin.

Approval is off because it "felt smoother."

The runbook is a 19-page novel, or it does not exist.

You tested by mailing a real customer.

They have not paused it themselves.

A password lives in a Google Doc titled "logins."

You added Slack "while you were there" without a quote.

Day 8 is quiet because you are afraid to ask, and you keep peeking.

Support quietly became a new feature.

If any of those are true, you do not call it shipped. You finish the handoff or you stop and refund the unused part. There is no "I'll watch it for a bit."

Pricing

The cash window is \$400–\$2,500 for named setups. Kai charges \$750 for form-to-draft-reply with approval, runbook, and 14-day support. Copy that until you have a reason not to. Put the number on the one-pager.

Ranges

\$400–\$500 if the flow is one trigger, one model call, one destination, and you already built it for yourself. First paid job only. Then move up.

\$750 for the default: form or inbox in, draft out, human approval, runbook, 14 days. This is Kai. This is you unless the tools are uglier.

\$1,200–\$2,500 if there are three tools, a messy existing sheet, or a compliance reason you have to move slowly. Still one named machine. Not a department.

Do not sell hourly "I'll hop in the workspace." Do not sell a retainer that says "automations as needed." Do not sell a \$99 special. They are not buying a zap. They are buying design, least privilege, tests, a runbook, and two weeks of you on the hook.

When to raise

After three setups that survived day 30, if you are turning work away or the tools got uglier. Raise \$750 to \$1,200 for messy sheets and three-tool jobs. Stay at \$750 for the clean form-to-draft you can now do in two sessions. Raise because the job is heavier, not because you bought a new tool.

If you charged \$500 once for a friend case, the next one is \$750. No story.

Refunds in one sentence

If it never ran on their accounts, or you cannot hand them a pause they can use, you refund. You do not refund because they dislike a draft the model wrote; that is why approval exists.

Never charge for these

Never charge to "look at their ops and see." That is a discovery you will not productize in month one. Never charge for a second flow inside the first fee. Never charge a monthly "I'll watch it" until several named setups have survived day 30, and even then name the hours and the machines. Never charge extra for the runbook. The runbook is the product. Never keep their tool bills inside your fee. They pay Zapier. You say that on the one-pager.

Worked dollars

Kai's first paid setup: \$750 in (\$375 to start, \$375 on handoff), a week of calendar time, maybe six to ten hours of real work including the walkthrough and runbook. Day 8 the drafts were still landing. That is the sale.

Three \$750 machines in a month is \$2,250 if you can staff the support windows without stacking three day-14s on the same Friday. Two at \$1,200 because the sheet was a mess is \$2,400 with more grinding. Worked dollars go up when you stop discounting the runbook and stop staying after day 14 "in case."

The first 72 hours

Do not hunt a client on day one. Demo on your own accounts first. A machine you cannot pause on your own login is not a product.

Day 1 morning: pick one setup and draw it

Form to draft reply is the cleanest first machine. You already understand email. The approval step is obvious. Draw it on one page: form submit, Make or Zapier, model with a voice doc, Gmail draft (not send), human taps Send. Circle the off switch. If you cannot draw the off switch, you do not collect a deposit later.

Write the voice rules in twelve lines, not a brand book. "Six sentences max. No 'excited to potentially explore.'" That file is what you will hand a client to edit.

Day 1 afternoon: build it on your accounts

Build it on your own form, your own inbox, a dummy customer name like "Test River." Submit four times. First drafts will be too long. Cut the voice doc. Save the fake-data tests. Put approval on. Practice pausing the scenario. If you cannot pause your own scenario, you have nothing to sell.

Day 1 night: record eight minutes

Record your screen: form submit, draft appears, you approve, mail would send. Stop the recording before you philosophize. Eight minutes. This is the sales asset. You will send it to two

people, not to the internet as a course.

Day 2: price and a one-pager

Write the sentence. \$750. Tools named: for example "Typeform or Tally, Gmail or Outlook, Claude or ChatGPT, Make or Zapier." One page: in, out, approval, runbook, 14 days, what is not included. Payment: 50 percent to start, 50 percent on handoff. They pay their tool bills. You say that on the page.

Do not design a logo. Do not pick an agency name. Sentence, tools, price, deposit.

Day 3: two offers, not ten

Send it to two people with messy inboxes. Not ten. Two who have complained in your hearing. "You said the lead form dumps into a void. I set up form-to-draft-reply with your approval. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. I can demo on my accounts this week." Attach or link the eight-minute recording if they want proof.

If they want a different machine, you may swap the name only if you can demo that one too. Do not invent a custom empire because they sounded excited. If both say no, send the same sentence to two more from the same pile on Friday. Do not spend Day 3 rewriting the offer into "AI operations."

The path, step by step

Do these in order. Building before the diagram is how you ship a clever knot. Collecting access before the deposit is how you work for free.

Name the machine in one line. If it needs a paragraph, split it into two products and sell one. "Form to draft reply with your approval" is a name. "Make their ops run on AI" is not. Write the before and the after. If you cannot, you are not selling yet.

Diagram on one page before you build. Trigger, tools, approval, destination, off switch. If you cannot draw the off switch, do not collect a deposit. The diagram is what you will paste into the invoice and the runbook. Keep it ugly and true.

Scope the tools in writing. "Make plus Gmail plus Claude" is a scope. "Whatever we need" is how invoices die. Name the form, the inbox or label, the model, the automation tool. They pay those bills. You say so.

Take a deposit. Then request access. Least privilege: the form, the one inbox or label, the one sheet. Not their Google admin. Not their personal inbox if a label will do. Write the access list in the same email as the invoice. If they send the admin password anyway, refuse it.

Build in a test environment. Fake names, fake emails you own, a dummy Slack channel. Never test by mailing their real customers. Submit four times. Save the runs. If the first drafts are wrong, you fix the voice doc, not the customer's reputation.

Put a human check on anything that sends, posts, or charges. They can ask to remove it later, in writing, after they have seen a week of drafts. If they want send-without-check on day one, you still run a week of approvals first. That is the deal.

Write the runbook: how to pause, how to know it broke, where the logs live, what "looks wrong" means in one example, who you are until day 14. One page. Screenshots of the toggle. A 19-page novel is how nobody pauses it.

Walk them through it live, twenty minutes, not a lecture. They pause it once with you watching. If they cannot pause it, you are not done. They submit one real or friend inquiry while you watch. A draft lands. They edit a sentence. That is the handoff moment.

Handoff in a folder they own. Invoice the rest. Calendar the 14-day end date and a day-8 check. Put the support end date in the runbook and in the email. Not "I'm around."

Support for 14 days is break-fix and small clarifications, not new features. A new branch in the flow is a new quote. Write down every change you made. That list is either a runbook update or a quote for setup two.

Day 8: they confirm it ran. You do not log in "just to check" unless they cannot send a screenshot. If it failed silently, you add a simple alert: an email when a run errors, or a daily count in a sheet. Then you write that into the runbook.

Day 14: you ask if they want a second named setup. If not, remove extra access you no longer need. Leave them as admin of their tools. Do not stay "in case." Watching it is unpaid ops.

Only then write an SOP for yourself so the second client is faster. Do not productize a setup you have never kept alive for a week. The SOP is your notes, not a course.

After three living setups, decide whether \$750 still matches the hours. If messy sheets ate you, the next messy one is \$1,200. If form-to-draft is now two sessions, keep it at \$750 and take more of them.

Keep a one-line log: date, machine name, fee, day-8 ran Y/N, support touches, still running at day 30. That log is how you know whether to raise, tighten scope, or stop. A sheet with five rows is enough. Do not buy a CRM for three clients.

Stop selling if a machine dies after you leave and you respond by moving back in. Fix the runbook and the off switch. If you cannot leave, you did not sell a setup. You sold a dependency.

A worked example: Kai's \$750 form-to-draft

Kai helps a three-person studio that takes project inquiries through a Tally form. The form currently emails everyone, and replies happen two days later, or not. The owner asked Kai to "put AI on our intake." Kai refused that sentence and sold a named setup instead.

Week minus one: demo on Kai's accounts

Monday, Kai draws form to Gmail draft with approval. Tuesday, Kai builds it on a personal Tally form and a dummy label. Dummy name: "River Test / never-use-this@kai.example." First drafts are too long. Voice doc gets a line: "Six sentences max." Wednesday, Kai records eight minutes. Thursday, Kai writes the one-pager at \$750, half to start. Friday, Kai messages two people. One is the studio owner who already complained.

The one-pager Kai sent

Named setup: form to draft reply with your approval. Tally to Gmail draft (not send) via Make. Claude writes the draft from a 12-line studio voice doc. You click Send. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. Half to start. You pay Make and Claude. Out: Slack, CRM, a second language, sending without approval.

The owner pays \$375. Kai asks for: Tally editor access, a Gmail label "Leads-drafts," and a shared Doc with three good replies they liked last year. Not the whole Google org. Not the client's personal inbox.

Build week, and the mistake

Monday: diagram. One page. Form submit to Make to Claude (voice doc plus form fields) to Gmail draft in the label to human sends. Off switch: a Make scenario toggle, circled in red, screenshot in the runbook.

Tuesday: fake data. Four submits. Drafts improve. Then Kai almost ships the first real mistake. The owner is eager and forwards a live inquiry "to try it." Kai has not turned on the draft-only path in the studio's Make yet. A send step is still live from a copy-paste. Kai catches it because the test email is Kai's. Kai deletes the send module, locks draft-only, and writes in the runbook: never connect a send step in week one. That catch is the product. Testing on a real customer would have been the end of the path.

Wednesday: walkthrough, twenty minutes. Owner pauses the scenario and unpauses it. Kai watches. Owner files a real inquiry from a friend's form. Draft lands. Owner edits one sentence and sends. Kai invoices the remaining \$375.

The runbook, what it actually says

How to pause: Make, scenario "Lead drafts," toggle off. Screenshot. How to know it broke: no draft in the label within ten minutes of a test submit. How to test: a form password Kai set, used only for tests. Who to ping until [date 14 days out]. What Kai will not do after that date without a new package: add Slack, add a second language, wire it to the CRM.

Day 8 and day 14

Day 8 the owner forwards three drafts that went out. One was too stiff; Kai tightens the voice doc inside support, not as a new product. Day 14 Kai removes Tally access, leaves the owner as Make admin, and asks if they want invoice reminders as a second named setup at \$750. Owner says later. Kai does not stay in the workspace "in case." The machine still runs. That is the first paid sale: \$750, still drafting on day 8.

The first stranger sale

Two weeks later the studio's bookkeeper mentions Kai to a two-person shop with a Typeform that dumps into a shared inbox. Kai sends the same one-pager. They pay \$375. Different form tool, same machine name. Kai demos the eight-minute recording, swaps Tally for Typeform in the diagram, and does not invent a CRM. Handoff on a Thursday. Remaining \$375. Day 8 they forward two drafts. That is the first stranger sale: \$750, on time, from a name Kai did not already work with. Kai still does not offer a retainer.

Copy you can actually send

Use these. Swap the machine. Do not add "AI-powered ops." Do not add a biography.

Post

You said the lead form dumps into a void. I set up form-to-draft-reply with your approval so nothing sends until you tap it. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. I can demo on my accounts this week.

DM

Named setup: form to draft reply with your approval. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. Half to start. I will not take admin access. I will not send without your tap. If the form is a mess, send me two sentences about what happens now.

Page hero

A named machine. Form to draft. Your approval. A runbook you can pause. 14 days of support. \$750.

Checkout line

\$750. 50 percent to start, 50 percent on handoff. In: one form, one draft destination, one model, human approval, one-page runbook, 14 days of break-fix. Out: extra tools, extra flows, sending without approval, retainers. You pay your Zapier or Make bill.

Email 1, the ask

Subject: Form to draft reply — \$750

You said the lead form dumps into a void. I set up form-to-draft-reply with your approval so nothing sends until you tap it. Runbook included. 14-day support. \$750. Half to start. I can demo on my accounts this week. If you want a different named machine, say the trigger and the result in one line.

Email 2, deposit in

Subject: Access list for [machine name]

Deposit is in. I need only: [form editor], [one inbox or label], [voice doc]. Not admin. I will diagram on one page, test with fake data I own, then walk you through a pause. Support ends [date] after handoff. New branches are a new quote.

Email 3, handoff

Subject: [Machine name] is yours — support until [date]

Folder: diagram, runbook, voice doc. Off switch is the first paragraph of the runbook. You paused it with me on [date]. Remaining invoice is attached. Day 8 I will ask for a screenshot that it ran. Day 14 I remove extra access. Break-fix until [date]. New features are a new quote.

Refund email

Subject: Refund for [machine name]

The setup never ran on your accounts / you cannot pause it without me. I am refunding [amount]. I will remove my access today. You do not need to reply.

What you do not write

"I'll automate your ops." "Unlimited zaps." "Set and forget forever." "I just need admin access to everything." Those sentences are how this path becomes a second unpaid job.

Week-by-week if you have a job

You can do this around a job if you protect two evenings in week 1 and a build block in week 2. Support is 14 days of being reachable, not 14 days of building.

Week 1

Day 1: pick the machine. Draw the off switch. Build the demo on your accounts. Fake data.

Day 2: record eight minutes. Write the \$750 one-pager. Test that you can pause your own scenario.

Day 3: two offers to people with messy inboxes. Send the recording if they ask.

Day 4: follow one non-reply with a single line. Do not rewrite the offer into a retainer.

Day 5: if a yes arrives, send the invoice for 50 percent. Do not request access before the deposit.

Day 6–7: if no yes, two more asks from the same pile. Do not start a website. Do not learn n8n if you already demo in Make.

Week 2

Day 8: deposit in. Access list, least privilege. Diagram in their folder.

Day 9–10: build on fake data. Approval on. No real customers.

Day 11: runbook. Screenshot of the toggle. Support end date written.

Day 12: twenty-minute walkthrough. They pause it. They see one draft. Invoice the rest.

Day 13–14: calendar day 8 and day 14 of the support window. Do not start a second client in the same week unless the first machine is already drafting.

Week 3

Support window. Break-fix only. Write down every change. Voice-doc tweaks are support. Slack and CRM are quotes. Day 8 of their machine: they send a screenshot. If it failed silently, add a

simple alert and put it in the runbook.

Week 4

Day 14: extra access removed. Ask once about a second named setup. If the first machine still runs, you may repeat the offer to two more people. If it does not run, you do not sell a second one. You fix your process. Log fee, day-8, support touches.

The quality bar

The bar is a machine a non-technical owner can pause, and a week of drafts that did not embarrass them. Clever is how you get an 11pm text in week three.

Below the bar

No diagram, or the diagram does not match the build.

No off switch, or they cannot find it.

Approval off on day one.

Tested on a real customer.

Admin access "because it was easier."

Runbook missing, or a 19-page novel.

Secrets in a shared Doc titled "logins."

Silent failure with no way they would know by tomorrow.

You still in the workspace after day 14 with no package.

A second flow shipped "while you were there."

Above the bar

One named machine. Tools named. Deposit taken.

Fake-data tests saved.

Approval on.

One-page runbook, screenshots of the toggle, support end date.

They paused it once in front of you.

Day 8 it ran without you poking it.

Day 14 extra access gone.

Simple alert if a run errors.

New features quoted, not gifted.

Five tests before you call it shipped

The pause test. They turn it off and on without you typing.

The fake-data test. Four submits to addresses you own. No real customer on the thread.

The match test. Diagram equals build. No surprise branches.

The day-8 test. They send a sample from the week. You did not log in to go fishing.

The leave test. You can remove extra access on day 14 and the machine still runs, because they own the tools.

If you fail one test, you are not "basically done." You fix it or you do not invoice the rest.

What to count

Count a short list. Module counts are vanity. Clients do not buy modules. They buy a named job that does not catch fire.

Week 1

Demo exists on your accounts: yes or no.

Off switch works on your login: yes or no.

One-pager live at \$750: yes or no.

Asks sent: target 2–4.

Deposits: target 1. A demo is not a sale.

Day 30

Setups handed off: target 1–2.

Day-8 ran without you: yes or no. This is the first-sale definition.

Real drafts or actions in week one. Zero means the trigger is wrong or they stopped feeding the form.

Support touches in 14 days. More than five usually means the runbook is thin or you sold a process they do not actually run.

Average fee. If you are stuck at \$400 after three, you are discounting the runbook away.

Extra access removed on day 14: yes or no.

Day 90

Machines still running at day 30 — ask once, do not babysit. Target: most of them.

Stranger sales: at least 1.

Fee at \$750 or \$1,200, not \$400.

Zero open retainers unless machines are named and hours are capped.

One SOP you actually reuse.

If day 90 is empty, you demoed and did not ask, or you asked people with no form and no inbox pain. Stop building tools. Send the sentence.

Ignore

How many modules the scenario uses. How "AI" the landing page sounds. Time spent choosing between Make and Zapier after you already have a demo. Compliments that are not a day-8 screenshot.

One-line spreadsheet

Date | machine name | fee | deposit date | handoff date | day-8 ran Y/N | support touches | day-14 access removed Y/N | still running day 30 Y/N

That is the whole system.

Objections you will hear — including your own

Reply once. Do not hold an architecture review in the thread.

"Can't they just turn on ChatGPT in the inbox?"

They can turn on a lot of things. They hired you so it drafts in their voice, waits for approval, and can be paused. Native buttons without a runbook are how a junior sends a wrong quote at 6am.

"\$750 feels high for a zap."

They are not buying a zap. They are buying design, least privilege, tests, a runbook, and two weeks of you on the hook. A \$20/month tool with no owner is cheaper and worse.

"They want it to send automatically."

Not on day one. Run a week of approvals. If they still want send-without-check, get it in writing, add a holdout (never mail a list they did not just submit), and keep the off switch obvious.

"I need admin access to do it right."

You need the least access that makes the named machine work. Admin access is how you become the person who "also" resets everyone's 2FA. Refuse god-mode.

"What if it breaks after day 14?"

They have the runbook. They can pay for a new package. You may sell a \$150 check-in. You may not pretend you are on call forever because you feel responsible for software they own.

"Can't you just do all our zaps?"

That is three machines or a \$2,500 scope with a written diagram. Default to one flow. You can stack later. One price for "all the zaps they might want" is how invoices die.

"We don't have a form."

Then the named setup is not form-to-draft. Sell a different named machine, or stand up a Tally form as part of the \$750 if you write it in the scope. Do not wander into a website rebuild.

"I don't write runbooks."

Then this is not your path. The runbook is half the product. A machine nobody can pause is a liability. Write one page or pick a different offer.

"Can I keep access so I can watch it?"

Not after day 14 unless they buy a check-in package. Watching it is how you become unpaid ops.

"What if the model writes a bad draft?"

That is why approval exists. Tighten the voice doc inside the 14 days. If they want a whole new tone for a second brand, that is a new quote.

What this feeds — and what feeds it

Keep the machine named. The minute you become "our automation person," you are on a salary they forget to pay.

What feeds a first automation job

A productized service client who is drowning in a form. A local business you already wrote posts for. A brief (path 18) whose next step was "configure the pipe," quoted separately. Yourself — the demo on your accounts is the sales asset. Cold "automation agency" ads are not how a kitchen-table operator gets job one.

People who already pay for Make, Zapier, or a model, and stall on the blank scenario, are easier than people who need you to sell them the whole stack.

What a living setup feeds

A second named machine for the same client, quoted separately. Invoice reminders after lead drafts. Slack after email. Always a new sentence.

A custom project setup (path 20) if they also need the model configured, not just the pipes.
New quote.

Notes that become a playbook or a template for a narrower audience, later, after you have done it three times.

A \$150 check-in, named, after day 30, if they ask. Not an open retainer in week two.

What not to feed

Do not feed a hosted-automation business where the scenario lives in your account. If you leave, the machine should not. Do not feed a staff workshop into the \$750. Do not use the runbook as a lead magnet with their voice doc still in it.

Mistakes that kill this path

God-mode logins. No off switch. Automating a process that has never been done manually. Leaving secrets in a shared doc. Those still kill it. The rest kill it more slowly.

Ten mistakes and the recovery this week

Starting to build before the diagram and the deposit. Recovery: stop. Draw the page. Send the invoice. Do not touch their tools until half is in.

Testing on real customers. Recovery: disconnect send. Rerun on fake addresses you own. If a real person got mail, say so, apologize, and put draft-only in the runbook today.

Skipping the approval step to look advanced. Recovery: turn approval on before the next run. Tell them why. A week of drafts is the deal.

A runbook that is a 19-page novel, or missing. Recovery: one page tonight. Pause, broken, logs, support end date. Screenshot of the toggle.

Support that quietly becomes new features. Recovery: send "That is a second machine. I can quote \$750." Then stop building it inside the first fee.

Staying in their workspace after day 14 "just in case." Recovery: remove extra access today. Offer a named check-in if they panic. Do not linger.

Quoting one price for "all the zaps they might want." Recovery: split the list into named machines. Sell one. Park the rest.

A password in a Google Doc titled "logins." Recovery: rotate the password. Move it to a password manager they own, or sit with them while they type it. Then delete the Doc.

Automating a job nobody does by hand. Recovery: pause the build. Have them do the job twice manually. If they will not, cancel and refund unused.

Taking admin because they offered it. Recovery: drop to the form, the label, the one sheet. Write the access list again. Refuse the rest.

Silent failure with no alert. Recovery: add an error email or a daily count. Put it in the runbook this week.

Learning a new automation tool on their dime. Recovery: finish this job in the tool you can demo. Learn the other one on your accounts next month.

If you catch yourself in any of these, the recovery is this week, not after you "stabilize the client." The client is not stabilized. The scope is.

Tools — only what you need

Pick one automation tool and get good at it. Make, Zapier, or n8n. Native Claude or ChatGPT connectors are enough for some jobs and better when the client already pays for them.

Whichever you can demo this week on your own accounts wins. Do not learn a new tool on their dime. If they already pay for one, prefer that.

Exact stack

One automation tool you can demo.

A form they already click (Tally, Typeform, native).

An email box or Slack channel they already live in.

A Doc for voice and the runbook.

Loom or a phone recording for the eight-minute demo and the walkthrough.

Stripe for the deposit and the rest.

A password manager they own. Not a shared Doc.

A calendar reminder for day 8 and day 14.

Setup order

Demo on your accounts, including pause.

Eight-minute recording.

One-pager at \$750, deposit language, tool bills are theirs.

Two asks.

Deposit, then access list.

Diagram in their folder.

Build on fake data.

Runbook, walkthrough, handoff.

Day 8, day 14.

What not to buy

Do not sell them a new CRM as a prerequisite. Do not rebuild their website to "capture leads properly" unless they paid for that as a different job. Do not buy an "AI agent platform" to look current. Do not buy a second automation tool so you can put logos on a page. The named setup uses what they already click.

The \$0 path

Use native connectors they already pay for (Gmail plus ChatGPT, or Claude plus a Google Sheet). A free Tally form. A free Make or Zapier tier if the volume fits, with the limit written down so nobody is surprised. Loom on a free plan, or your phone. Stripe or the payment tool you already

have. The \$0 path is for the demo and maybe job one. It is not an excuse to skip the runbook, the approval step, or the deposit.

Checklist

- Machine named in one line, before and after
- One-page diagram includes the off switch
- Tools listed in the quote
- They pay their Zapier or Make bill, written
- 50 percent deposit before access
- Least privilege, not admin
- Access list in the same email as the invoice
- Fake data tests saved, four submits
- Human approval on send, post, or charge
- Voice or rules doc they can edit
- Runbook: pause, broken, logs, support end date
- Screenshot of the toggle in the runbook
- They pause it once in front of you
- Twenty-minute walkthrough, not a lecture
- Handoff folder they own
- Remaining invoice at handoff
- Day 8 check: it still ran
- Simple alert if a run errors
- Day 14: extra access removed
- New features = new quote
- No secrets in a shared Doc
- No testing on real customers

Process has been done manually at least twice

Calendar for day 8 and day 14

One-line spreadsheet row filled

Second machine is a second sentence

You can leave and it still runs

FAQ

Make, Zapier, or n8n?

Whichever you can demo this week on your own accounts. Do not learn a new tool on their dime. If they already pay for one, prefer that. Default: the tool in your eight-minute recording.

What if they do not have a form?

Then the named setup is not form-to-draft. Sell a different named machine, or stand up a Tally form as part of the \$750 if you write it in the scope. Do not wander. Default: one machine, written.

Do I include the Zapier bill in my fee?

No. They pay their tool bills. You say that on the one-pager. Your \$750 is design, build, runbook, 14 days. Default: their accounts, their bills.

Can I keep access so I can "watch it"?

Not after day 14 unless they buy a check-in package. Watching it is how you become unpaid ops. Default: extra access removed on day 14.

What if the model writes a bad draft?

That is why approval exists. Tighten the voice doc inside the 14 days. If they want a whole new tone for a second brand, that is a new quote. Default: approval stays on.

Is \$750 too much for a first client who is a friend?

Charge \$500 once if you need a case, then \$750. Free is how friends get a machine you cannot afford to support. Default: \$750 after one discounted case.

Should I sell a monthly retainer?

Not until several named setups have survived day 30. Even then, name the hours and the machines. "Retainer for automations" is the leave-this-alone line. Default: named setups only in month one.

What if they want Slack, email, and the CRM in week one?

That is three machines or a \$2,500 scope with a written diagram. Default to one flow. You can stack later.

How do I handle API keys?

In their account. Not in yours. Not in a chat log. If a key leaked into a screenshot, rotate it before you go to bed. Default: their password manager.

When is the first sale "real"?

When the setup still runs a week later. A demo on your laptop is not a first sale. Kai's first sale was the studio's drafts on day 8. Default: day 8 yes.

What if they ghost after the deposit?

You still have the diagram and the access list. Email once. If access never arrives, the clock on your build does not start, and you keep the deposit for the week you held, or you refund if you wrote a different rule. Default: write the rule on the one-pager before the first dollar.

Do I have to be on Slack with them?

No. Email is enough. A shared Doc for the runbook is enough. Slack is how support becomes a second job. Default: email plus the runbook folder.

Can I use their live leads as tests?

No. Fake names, fake emails you own. Default: never.

What if Make's native Gmail connector is enough and they do not want a model?

Then the machine might be form to labeled draft with a template, no model. Same product shape, maybe \$500–\$750. Do not force a model into a job that is a template. Default: name the job, not the model.

How long until I can productize this as a template?

After three living setups of the same machine. Generic runbook, no client voice docs. That is a later path. Default: do not sell a template of a setup you have run once.